

What kind of results have you had so far?

Because of New York State law, you have to start charter schools small. We started with grades K and 1, and then added a grade each year. Under New York law, if we started any larger, we would automatically be unionized. It's a law the unions have helped pass to handicap the growth of charter schools. Since testing grades are grades three through eight, only four of our schools have reached testing grade so far. The four schools that were tested last year beat Scarsdale, Great Neck, and all the top school districts in the state.

Where were these four schools?

The schools were all in Harlem.

With the success you've had, don't you face the problem of too many parents trying to get their kids into your school relative to the space you have?

The only way to get into a charter school is through a lottery, and we have about nine kids applying for every spot.

What did you think of the film *Waiting for Superman*?

Harlem Success was actually one of the schools profiled in the movie. There was also another excellent documentary, *The Lottery*, which focused solely on Harlem Success.

Do you think there is some hope that your program may help change the way government-run schools operate?

I think eventually it will. K–12 education in the United States is a \$600 billion business, and philanthropy can't be the answer. All that philanthropy can do is to show the way. Charter schools are public schools, but they are independently run. Eva and her team have shown that it's not the kids' fault. We have the same kids as the publicly run schools. We get them by lottery. And it's not that the parents don't care; they do. It's not because there is not enough money; we actually run our schools for less money per student. So the bottom line is that we have the same kids, same parents, and less money. If our charter schools can continue to demonstrate success, it will hopefully remove the main excuses for why publicly run schools are unsuccessful. I am not